Case analysis: Seth, inclusion and behavioral support plan

Chapter 12 · Katherine Conklin

Student: Seth **Grade:** 3rd **Diagnosis:** High-functioning autism **Placement:** General education classroom

Legal framework

- **IDEA (2004):** Seth is entitled to a Free and Appropriate Public Education (FAPE) in the Least Restrictive Environment (LRE). Schools must provide necessary supports and accommodations before placing a student in a more restrictive setting.
- **FAPE:** Seth must receive individualized support that ensures meaningful academic and social progress.
- **LRE:** before considering a special class placement, the school must exhaust all inclusion supports.
- **Behavioral supports requirement:** IDEA requires a Functional Behavioral Assessment and a Behavior Intervention Plan before considering a change in placement due to behavior concerns.
- **Endrew F. v. Douglas County School District (2017):** schools must ensure that students with disabilities receive an appropriately ambitious education plan that enables meaningful progress. Seth's current placement is not leading to sufficient behavioral progress, so his IEP may require modifications.
- **Oberti v. Board of Education (1993):** schools must provide necessary supports for inclusion before moving a student to a self-contained classroom. Seth's team must demonstrate that all reasonable accommodations have been attempted.

Concerns

Social communication

- **Fixation on special interests:** Seth talks excessively about weather patterns, making it difficult to engage in reciprocal conversations
- **Limited peer engagement:** Seth does not relate to peer topics and struggles to form meaningful friendships
- **Literal thinking and rule enforcement:** he corrects students' behavior, which irritates peers and leads to social rejection

Behavioral concerns

- **Aggression in group work:** Seth dominates group projects and becomes aggressive when students disagree with his approach
- **Emotional dysregulation:** he struggles with frustration when unexpected changes occur

- **Difficulty with flexible thinking:** Seth resists negotiation and compromise, making cooperative learning difficult

Teacher and classroom concerns

- **Impact on peers:** Seth's behavior creates tension among students, leading to exclusion and bullying
- **Teacher overload:** Liz is responsible for standardized test preparation and lacks special education training
- **Paraprofessional's role:** Kara, the classroom aide, is responsible for multiple students, limiting her ability to provide individualized support

Functional Behavioral Assessment and Behavior Intervention Plan

Identified triggers (antecedents)

- **Group work:** Seth feels the need to control projects, leading to conflicts
- **Unstructured social situations:** free play, transitions, and unexpected changes result in anxiety and aggression
- **Peers not following rules:** when classmates break minor rules, Seth corrects them forcefully, creating hostility

Consequences and reinforcement

- Due to aggressive outbursts, students exclude him from social activities
- When the teacher or paraprofessional intervenes, it reinforces Seth's dependence on adult intervention rather than self-regulation
- Without structured intervention, Seth's behaviors become more severe

Replacement behaviors and intervention strategies

- **Teach social flexibility:** use social stories to model compromise and peer interactions
- **Behavioral reinforcement:** reward positive social behaviors using a token system
- **Self-regulation tools:** teach coping strategies (deep breathing, movement breaks)
- **Structured group roles:** assign specific tasks during group work to prevent Seth from dominating
- **Predictable routines:** use visual schedules to prepare Seth for transitions

Recommendations for Seth's placement and support

Modify Seth's IEP

- **Social skills training:** weekly sessions with a speech therapist for pragmatic language development
- **Behavioral support:** a structured BIP that includes self-monitoring strategies
- **Structured peer interactions:** assign a peer mentor to model appropriate social behaviors

Strengthening inclusion supports

- **Professional development for Liz and Kara:** train staff on ASD interventions and behavioral de-escalation techniques
- Provide sensory breaks to help Seth self-regulate emotions

- Assign clear roles in group work to prevent power struggles
- Use visual supports to reinforce flexible thinking and transitions

Addressing parent and teacher concerns

- **For Seth's parents:** maintain weekly progress check-ins, and allow structured, supervised social activities to practice peer interactions
- **For Liz:** offer consultation with a behavior specialist to implement positive reinforcement, and use structured lesson planning that builds on Seth's strengths (for example, a weather-related project)

Final placement consideration: inclusion vs. special education

Seth should remain in general education if

- A structured BIP is developed and implemented successfully
- His aggressive outbursts decrease, and he learns self-regulation skills
- He shows progress in peer interactions through structured support

Consider partial special education placement if

- Seth continues to disrupt the learning environment despite interventions
- He fails to make social and behavioral progress after 6 to 8 weeks of intensive support
- His anxiety and aggression worsen, leading to emotional distress

Conclusion

Seth is a bright student with strong academic potential, but his social and behavioral challenges require structured intervention. His IEP must be modified to include social skills training, a structured BIP, and classroom accommodations. Inclusion should remain the goal, but if targeted interventions do not lead to improvement, a hybrid model or partial special education placement should be considered.

By collaborating with teachers, parents, and specialists, Seth's academic and social success can be maximized while ensuring a safe and inclusive classroom environment.